

Who or what is actually using AI enough to justify it's enormous computing power demands?

Posted by u/AIGenerated-Username • • 0 points • 9 comments

I just read an article saying that AI data centers will purchase and use almost all of the RAM manufactured in 2026. Furthermore, I have seen articles explaining that AI data centers will require their own nuclear reactors just to power themselves. Combining just these two, ignoring for a second all of the other crazy shenanigans the AI industry is up to, this is an absolutely incomprehensibly insane amount of computing power.

This context leads into my question(s): who is actually using this much computing power? Let alone frequently enough to justify its insane costs? Is there a specific industry that is using AI 24/7 to justify these insane costs? Is there any one sector or industry we can point to that actually needs an AI that uses this much computing power? Is all this power being used by average users on ChatGPT or Gemini, etc? Or is it just AI being needlessly implemented into everything in the hopes that one day people will use this computing power? Alternatively, is it just being built to train bigger and better AI models, which just again compounds the question; for whom?

Comments

u/sceadwian • 1 points • 2026-01-19 20:29 UTC

Running the AI is not very demanding relatively speaking, training it is.

Those data centers are used for training the AI.

u/Anxious_Camp_2160 • 1 points • 2026-01-19 15:39 UTC

I asked ChatGPT the answer, it told me a patient in Uzbekistan just died as the power from his ventilator was used to generate the answer to this question.

u/Lumpy-Notice8945 • 2 points • 2026-01-19 15:03 UTC

Dont blindly trust every news article.

AI as a whole industry is booming, thats why the whole industry is using a lot of power. A single AI

model isn't actually that expensive at all, you can run image generation on a gaming PC and LLMs aka chatbots on phone hardware. These news articles mash together datacenters and AI but not every datacenter is for AI and a whole industry compared to a single town's water usage of course sounds like it's a lot. Having an AC in a server room to cool it isn't specific to AI, Google Search or Netflix do the same.

u/CopingAdult • 0 points • 2026-01-19 15:02 UTC

Loads of ppl, and that's the problem; they will soon do a rug pull, and make everyone pay. We're in the honeymoon / grace period / free trial era now. And our data is the fodder.

u/SharpestOne • 2 points • 2026-01-19 20:06 UTC

They can't really do a rug pull without destroying their own business.

Too many models any fool can run on HuggingFace already.

u/ExcessivePlumbing • -2 points • 2026-01-19 14:52 UTC

You forget the main and the most important use case.

Jeff Bezos and Elon Musk are using AI to get rich.

If they have to drink all the water and use up all the electricity, it's totally justified. The average ~~~consumer can get by without those for a year or five, right?

u/ForScale • 2 points • 2026-01-19 14:47 UTC

I use it everyday at work. Am programmer.

u/Thin-Cycle-7361 • 1 points • 2026-01-19 14:41 UTC

Most of it is probably going to training new models rather than actual users tbh. Like everyone's trying to build the next GPT-5 and that takes absolutely bonkers amounts of compute, but then the actual inference (when you chat with it) is way less intensive

The crazy part is companies are basically betting billions that someone will eventually find a killer use case that justifies all this infrastructure, but right now it feels like we're in the "build it and they will come" phase

u/LilaPrieya • 0 points • 2026-01-19 14:40 UTC

it's just tech CEOs having a massive arms race to build the biggest god model first and they're just gonna figure out how to actually use it later